

# LESSONS ON RENEWAL FROM NEHEMIAH

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Nehemiah was born more than a thousand miles away from Jerusalem to a captive people. He had never seen the land of his ancestors though he had heard countless stories of its former beauty, glory and fame. Before Nehemiah's birth, the first group of Jews had left Persia and returned to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple under the leadership of Zerubbabel in 538 B.C. A second group had returned under the leadership of Ezra in 458 B.C., 13 years before Act One of Nehemiah.

Nehemiah was not a priest, but a trusted administrator, a cupbearer, one who was a trusted confidante of the king, who would ask permission to be sent to Jerusalem to help rebuild the crumbling walls of Jerusalem in a record-setting pace of 52 days.

The first half of Nehemiah describes the miraculous task of constructing the walls of stone and mortar against great peril and all odds. The second half of Nehemiah describes the miracle of the transformation of hearts when Nehemiah helps the people's hearts be transformed by a willingness to conform to God's covenants and promises. A commitment to the Word of God does this. The internal transformation of hearts and attitudes toward their God is as miraculous as the outward task of building walls in the presence of enemies.

For this study, we will examine the steps of renewal towards the last half of Nehemiah that resulted in the new presence of Israel in Jerusalem as they apply to our renewal and presence in the kingdom of God.

## Steps towards Spiritual Renewal

### 1. Returning To The Word Of God

Ezra Reads the Law:

*"And all the people gathered as one man into the square before the Water Gate. And they told Ezra the scribe to bring the Book of the Law of Moses that the LORD had commanded Israel. So Ezra the priest brought the Law before the assembly, both men and women and all who could understand what they heard, on the first day of the seventh month. And he read from it facing the square before the Water Gate from early morning until midday, in the presence of the men and the women and those who could understand. And the ears of all the people were **attentive** to the Book of the Law. And Ezra the scribe stood on a wooden platform that they had made for the purpose. And beside him stood Mattithiah, Shema, Anaiah, Uriah, Hilkiah, and Maaseiah on his right hand, and Pedaiah, Mishaël, Malchijah, Hashum, Hashbaddanah, Zechariah, and Meshullam on his left hand. And Ezra opened the book in the sight of all the*

people, for he was above all the people, and as he opened it all the people stood. And Ezra blessed the LORD, the great God, and all the people answered, **'Amen, Amen,' lifting up their hands.** And they bowed their heads and worshiped the LORD with their faces to the ground. Also Jeshua, Bani, Sherebiah, Jamin, Akkub, Shabbethai, Hodiah, Maaseiah, Kelita, Azariah, Jozabad, Hanan, Pelaiah, the Levites, **helped the people to understand** the Law, while the people remained in their places. They read from the book, from the Law of God, clearly, and they gave the sense, so that the people understood the reading" (Nehemiah 8:1-8, ESV).

Everything begins and ends with the Word of God! Every renewal, every revival, every new birth is born in the Word of God. We need to fall in love with the Word of God. I appreciate many of the word picture phrases that seem to leap out at us from these scriptures such as:

1. Understand what they heard.
2. The ears of all the people were attentive.
3. All the people answered, *"Amen, Amen," lifting up their hands.*
4. And bowed their heads and worshiped the Lord with their faces to the ground.
5. The Levites helped the people understand.
6. Clearly, they gave the sense so that the people understood the reading.

These descriptive phrases give the impression that these souls were taking the Word of God seriously. The Word of God was taking root in their souls, which was the beginning of our renewal and revival.

## 2. Commitment To Obedience To The Word Of God

After hearing the Word of God read and proclaimed publically, it became evident that they had not obeyed the command to practice the Old Testament Feast of Booths, which they immediately made provisions for. The important fact to note for us today is that when the Lord begins to reveal to us in "our hour" His requirements we should be mindful to "obey" as well.

When reading Nehemiah 8:13-18 there are action verbs included such as, "came, study, found, proclaim, publish, brought, made, lived, read." Words that reinforce the idea that the people after hearing the Word of God proclaimed had great "intent" to follow through and obey. When God speaks to us in our present hour, let us be intent to obey with the same zeal.

*"On the second day the heads of fathers' houses of all the people, with the priests and the Levites, came together to Ezra the scribe in order to study the words of the Law. And they found it written in the Law that the LORD had commanded by Moses that the people of Israel should dwell in booths during the feast of the seventh month, and that they should proclaim it and publish it in all their towns and in Jerusalem, 'Go out to the hills and bring branches of olive, wild olive, myrtle,*

*palm, and other leafy trees to make booths, as it is written.' So the people went out and brought them and made booths for themselves, each on his roof, and in their courts and in the courts of the house of God, and in the square at the Water Gate and in the square at the Gate of Ephraim. And all the assembly of those who had returned from the captivity made booths and lived in the booths, for from the days of Jeshua the son of Nun to that day the people of Israel had not done so. And there was very great rejoicing. And day by day, from the first day to the last day, he read from the Book of the Law of God. They kept the feast seven days, and on the eighth day there was a solemn assembly, according to the rule" (Nehemiah 8:13-18, ESV).*

## 3. Convicted And Confessed Their Sins

The reading and application of the Word of God, caused the people to confess their sins and repent. This is so very important for personal revival, for personal salvation, for personal renewal. We must not become too comfortable with our sins. We need to call our sins, a sin. There is a new buzz word in the hour we live in that disguises our sins. It is called "our truth." Often someone will live in sin and just call it "my truth." I am living in "my truth." I have news for you my friend, there is only one truth, and that is Jesus Christ, the way the truth, and the life. We need to live in His truth.

*"And the Israelites separated themselves from all foreigners and stood and confessed their sins and the iniquities of their fathers" (Nehemiah 9:2, ESV).*

*"If we say we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us. If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness" (1 John 1:8-9, ESV).*

## 4. They Learned To Give Great And Continuous Worship And Praise To God

Intertwined with their confession of sin, God's people learned to give continual worship and praise to their God. God is to be praised for all that He is, for all that He has done, and for all that He shall do. Praise opens the door to the heavens and grants entry into the presence of God. It is the sacrifice that opens the ears of our Father to the petitions of His children.

In their praises to God, the saints reminded the Lord as part of their worship of His greatness and His faithfulness. It is good to rehearse the goodness of God.

*"You are the LORD, you alone. You have made heaven, the heaven of heavens, with all their host, the earth and all that is on it, the seas and all that is in them; and you preserve all of them; and the host of heaven worships you. You are the LORD, the God who chose Abram and brought him out of Ur of the Chaldeans and gave him the name Abraham. You found his heart faithful before you, and made with him the covenant to give to his offspring the land of the Canaanite, the Hittite, the Amorite, the Perizzite, the Jebusite, and the Girgashite. And you have kept your promise, for you are righteous. And you saw the affliction of our fathers in Egypt and heard their cry at the Red Sea, and performed signs and wonders against Pharaoh*



*and all his servants and all the people of his land, for you knew that they acted arrogantly against our fathers. And you made a name for yourself, as it is to this day. And you divided the sea before them, so that they went through the midst of the sea on dry land, and you cast their pursuers into the depths, as a stone into mighty waters. By a pillar of cloud you led them in the day, and by a pillar of fire in the night to light for them the way in which they should go. You came down on Mount Sinai and spoke with them from heaven and gave them right rules and true laws, good statutes and commandments, and you made known to them your holy Sabbath and commanded them commandments and statutes and a law by Moses your servant. You gave them bread from heaven for their hunger and brought water for them out of the rock for their thirst, and you told them to go in to possess the land that you had sworn to give them” (Nehemiah 9:6-15, ESV).*

*“But the hour is coming, and is now here when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth, for the Father is seeking such people to worship him” (John 4:23, ESV).*

*“Through him then let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to God, that is, the fruit of lips that acknowledge his name” (Hebrews 13:15, ESV).*

### **5. Commitment To The Lord In Conduct And Finances**

Talk is cheap! This is a common saying often expressed when someone boasts about something but is not willing to invest in it personally. The saints at this step in their renewal realized that they needed to commit to God. If you read Nehemiah 9:38 through to about 10:39, you will find that God’s people signed a covenant with God to follow the Lord and to observe His laws. Also to pay their tithes for the service to the house of the Lord.

God asks all of us to make a covenant with Him and to fulfill our personal responsibilities.

#### ***The Obligations of the Covenant***

*“The rest of the people, the priests, the Levites, the gatekeepers, the singers, the temple servants, and all who have separated themselves from the peoples of the lands to the Law of God, their wives, their sons, their daughters, all who have knowledge and understanding, join with their brothers, their nobles, and enter into a curse and an oath to walk in God’s Law that was given by Moses the servant of God, and to observe and do all the commandments of the LORD our Lord and his rules and his statutes. We will not give our daughters to the peoples of the land or take their daughters for our sons. And if the peoples of the land bring in goods or any grain on the Sabbath day to sell, we will not buy from them on the Sabbath or on a holy day. And we will forego the crops of the seventh year and the exaction of every debt. We also take on ourselves the obligation to give yearly a third part of a shekel for the service of the house of our God: for the showbread, the regular grain offering, the regular burnt offering, the Sabbaths, the new moons, the appointed feasts, the holy things, and the sin offerings to make atonement for Israel, and for all the work of the house of our God. We, the priests, the Levites, and the people, have likewise cast lots for the wood offering, to bring it into the house of our God,*

*according to our fathers’ houses, at times appointed, year by year, to burn on the altar of the LORD our God, as it is written in the Law. We obligate ourselves to bring the firstfruits of our ground and the firstfruits of all fruit of every tree, year by year, to the house of the LORD; also to bring to the house of our God, to the priests who minister in the house of our God, the firstborn of our sons and of our cattle, as it is written in the Law, and the firstborn of our herds and of our flocks; and to bring the first of our dough, and our contributions, the fruit of every tree, the wine and the oil, to the priests, to the chambers of the house of our God; and to bring to the Levites the tithes from our ground, for it is the Levites who collect the tithes in all our towns where we labor. And the priest, the son of Aaron, shall be with the Levites when the Levites receive the tithes. And the Levites shall bring up the tithe of the tithes to the house of our God, to the chambers of the storehouse” (Nehemiah 10:28-38, ESV).*

*“And if it is evil in your eyes to serve the LORD, choose this day whom you will serve, whether the gods your fathers served in the region beyond the River; or the gods of the Amorites in whose land you dwell. But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD” (Joshua 24:15, ESV).*

*“Will man rob God? Yet you are robbing me. But you say, ‘How have we robbed you?’ In your tithes and contributions. You are cursed with a curse, for you are robbing me, the whole nation of you. Bring the full tithe into the storehouse, that there may be food in my house. And thereby put me to the test, says the LORD of hosts, if I will not open the windows of heaven for you and pour down for you a blessing until there is no more need” (Malachi 3:8-10, ESV).*

### **6. They Offered Their Lives For Service To The Lord**

At this point in history, not many lived in Jerusalem. They were starting over! The walls had been rebuilt and it was a fresh restart. The economy had to be jump-started and there was a need to populate the city. The city was for the most part empty and not the bustling city that we have the image of today.

Therefore, they repopulated the city of Jerusalem by drawing lots to bring in one-tenth, or a tithe of the country’s total population to the city, plus other volunteers such as laymen, priests, Levites, gatekeepers, temple servants, and others. I find it interesting that Jerusalem was repopulated on a tithe of total population. But they offered themselves for service!! This should be the attitude of every one of us.

There is a saying in the sales world, that applies in many industries, that 80% of sales is from 20% of the sales force, or 20% of the sales force does 80% of the work. I don’t know how true that is, but in God’s economy, He wants 100% of His work done by 100% of His church. We should all offer ourselves for service to the Lord to fit in His body as He sees fit.

#### ***The Leaders in Jerusalem***

*“Now the leaders of the people lived in Jerusalem. And the rest of the people cast lots to bring one out of ten to live in Jerusalem the holy city, while nine out of ten remained in the other towns. **And the people blessed all the men who willingly***

*offered to live in Jerusalem”* (Nehemiah 11:1-2, ESV).

### 7. Giving Of Great Thanks To God (Worship Again!)

The completed wall (completed in 52 days) was dedicated and a great celebration of praise and worship was given to the Lord. Worship and praise are so very important. The Lord’s prayer begins and ends with an ascription of praise. This was a model prayer teaching us to begin our prayers and end our prayers with praise and worship.

“After this manner therefore pray ye: **Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name.** Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven. Give us this day our daily bread. And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors. And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil: **For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, forever. Amen”** (Matthew 6:9-13, KJV).

### Dedication of the Wall

*“And at the dedication of the wall of Jerusalem they sought the Levites in all their places, to bring them to Jerusalem to celebrate the dedication with gladness, with thanksgivings and with singing, with cymbals, harps, and lyres”* (Nehemiah 12:27, ESV).

*“The other choir of those who gave thanks went to the north, and I followed them with half of the people, on the wall, above the Tower of the Ovens, to the Broad Wall”* (Nehemiah 12:38, ESV).

*“So both choirs of those who gave thanks stood in the house of God, and I and half of the officials with me”* (Nehemiah 12:40, ESV).

### 8. Don’t Compromise

The world loves a compromise. If the enemy of your soul can not have you in his army, the next best thing is to get you to compromise on your beliefs. The infamous words of the serpent in the garden were “Did God say?” In other words, he planted a question that caused compromise.

Nehemiah chapter 13 tells the story of many compromises of the sabbath day and of intermarriage with non-believers.

One passage I find striking is as follows:

*“In those days I also saw Jews who had married women of Ashdod, Ammon, and Moab. And half of their children spoke the language of Ashdod, and could not speak the language of Judah, but spoke according to the language of one or the other people”* (Nehemiah 13:23-24, NKJV).

These women had intermarried, and half their children spoke another language. Young people, when you become unequally yoked with an unbeliever, often your children will speak the language of the unbeliever, and follow the lifestyle of the unbeliever, with eternal consequences. I don’t mean the language of Spanish or Greek; I mean the lifestyle language of the unbeliever. God wants our homes to be blessed with us speaking the same “spiritual language.”

*“I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that you present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable to God, which is your reasonable service. And do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, that you may prove what is that good and acceptable and perfect will of God”* (Romans 12:1-2, NKJV).

Hopefully, these steps of renewal that Israel experienced under the revival of Nehemiah can be applied to our hearts today. 

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